just fall back on the past monsoon-driven one, though we should not underestimate the attractions of soft connectivity. The problem is that littoral nations, in the last five decades, have each joined a regional grouping, some of them more than one. Going across the ocean, we have a parade of acronyms that testify to its fractures: SADC, GCC, SAARC, BIMSTEC, ASEAN, EAS, etc. Encouraging nations and regions to work towards a composite Indian Ocean one is, therefore, not easy. None probably would be opposed, but few actually have the necessary enthusiasm.

At a diplomatic level, promoting greater interaction among these groupings would itself make a contribution. It is also useful to bridge physically the boundaries between them. A good example is the India-Myanmar border where SAARC meets ASEAN. While land connectivity is obviously critical, we must also recognize that the underdevelopment of maritime infrastructure is itself largely responsible for the profile of the Indian Ocean. No less significant is hinterland development. Part of the Indian Ocean's limitation was the narrowness of its coastal culture. As unified national societies emerged in Asia, the psychological distance from the ocean also narrowed. Hinterland economies have increasingly become linked to maritime trade. It is apparent today that the development of their infrastructure can be a game changer in elevating the importance of the Indian Ocean.

The centrality of the Indian Ocean to global trade and development is not a fresh realization. After all, it covers one-fifth of the world's total ocean area and encapsulates coastlines of almost 70,000 km. But more than the expanse, it is about location. With Asia's economic revival, whether we see the region as markets or production centres, transportation of goods has only acquired greater salience. The flow of natural resources is correspondingly growing with this ocean now accounting for two-thirds of the world's maritime oil trade. More than two-fifths of the world's population lives around the ocean. Ensuring the smooth and uninterrupted flow of one-third of the world's bulk cargo and half its container traffic is not a small responsibility. With the passage of time, it must also become an increasingly collective one.